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Sociology and Social Change

Week 8 Monday — When the explanation is not in the individual

NRES 315: Human Dimensions of Fish and Wildlife Management

Last updated: 2026-10-06

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Last week we looked inside the person

Psychology asked what a person believes, intends, and feels, and what the situation in front of them allows.

This week the unit of analysis changes. **Sociology asks about the patterns that exist beyond any one person** — and that shape what any individual can believe, intend, or do.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.2

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Today's question

When thousands of people give the same individual reason, what are we actually looking at?

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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What you should be able to do

By the end of today, you should be able to:

- distinguish **structure** and **agency**, and explain why you need both;
- define a **social fact** and distinguish a private **trouble** from a public **issue**;
- explain **social construction** and give a fish-and-wildlife example; and
- define **social order** and **social change**.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.3.1–9.3.5

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Structure and agency

Society shapes people. People reshape society.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.1

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Two words, one relationship

Structure	Agency
The stable, patterned relationships among societal elements that influence human action: institutions, roles, norms.	The capacity of individuals to act independently and make choices.

Structuration: people's interactions create and renegotiate structures, while individuals act within the contexts those structures produce.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.1

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The river and its banks

A river's **banks** guide its **flow**.

The flow gradually **reshapes the banks**.

Society influences human behavior while individuals actively reshape society.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.1

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Applied: why did participation change?

A sociologist asks structural questions:

- Has urbanization made the landscape harder to access?
- Have rural communities — traditionally a primary source of social support for hunting — declined in population?
- Have those areas changed in **character**, even where headcount held?

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.1 and Box 9.1

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Social facts

Values, norms, and structures that exist outside any one person.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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Durkheim's move

The decision to die by suicide is intensely personal. Yet rates vary enormously across places, groups, and eras.

An explanation that works only at the individual level cannot explain why the **rate** differs. Durkheim found social support to be a strong predictor of aggregate rates.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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Troubles and issues

C. Wright Mills:

Troubles	Issues
Private experiences. One person's schedule got busier. One person lost a place to hunt.	The same troubles, when they become widespread across a population — and call for examining structural conditions.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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Social construction

Concepts created through human interaction and maintained by collective agreement.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.3

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Game fish and rough fish

Both are real animals. The **categories** are social constructs.

- "Game fish" are constructed as desirable, so policy promotes them: creel, length, and gear limits.
- "Rough fish," often **native** species, are constructed as less valuable — so many go unregulated entirely: no creel, bag, or gear limit.

Saying a category is socially constructed does not mean it is imaginary. It means the agreement is what produces the regulation.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.3

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What is not socially constructed

Gravity. Temperature. Thermodynamics.

Professionals constantly negotiate the tension between biophysical realities that no belief can alter and social constructions that determine what we do about them.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.3

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Social order and social change

Social order: the structures, institutions, facts, and constructs that maintain stability — and which can also produce inequalities of status, role, and position.

Social change: transformation of basic social structures and institutions over time, often originating in economics, politics, technology, or natural realities.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.3.4–9.3.5

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Pair rehearsal: trouble or issue?

With a partner, decide which each is, and name the structural question you would ask:

1. "I lost my hunting spot when the neighbor sold the farm."
2. 63% of lapsed hunters in a county say they have "nowhere to go."
3. "I don't have time anymore."
4. Commuting over 30 minutes rose from 19% to 46% of county residents.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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Wednesday and Friday

Wednesday: the three sociological perspectives, plus socialization, identity, community, place, and stratification.

Before Friday: read the **Week 08 Case Brief: Who Still Hunts Cedar County?** It is a separate document in the Canvas module and is required preparation.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.4–9.6

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Close

A widespread pattern of personal troubles calls for examining social conditions. Individual experience and structural explanation belong together.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.3.2

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